

The Spanish Steps

Location Rome, Italy

The sinuous cascade of Rome's Spanish Steps, built between 1721 and 1727, is both the final flourish of the city's ambitious Baroque urban schemes and the best example of the period's dramatic use of steps as an architectural device. They sweep commandingly between the church of the Trinità dei Monti at their summit and the Piazza di Spagna at their foot—hence the name. Halfway up is a terrace; as the steps rise toward it, they narrow. As they pass the terrace, the steps

widen before narrowing and then widening again to pass a further terrace at the summit. The obelisk in front of the church is a later addition, erected in 1786.

Melk Abbey

Location Melk, Austria

Completed in 1736, Jakob Prandtauer's late-Baroque Benedictine abbey and church at Melk takes full advantage of its setting on a rocky spur above the River Danube. Long and low under its steep-pitched red roofs, it rises

to a glorious crown in the church itself. This sits in an apsed courtyard formed by the projecting wings of the monastery, over which two highly ornate towers rise under onion domes picked out in gold and green. Behind them is a double dome on a high drum. The impact is heightened by the color scheme of white-and-ocher stucco. The slightly later interior of the church is a symphony of deep-red marble and gold under soaring frescoes.

Amalienburg

Location Munich, Germany

If the Rococo was essentially a decorative rather than architectural style, the Amalienburg, built between 1734 and 1739 on the grounds of the Nymphenburg Palace on Munich's outskirts, is its supreme expression. Externally, the Amalienburg is a modest, one-story structure. Internally, it explodes in a riot of precise decoration. The dazzling highlight is the circular Hall of Mirrors at the heart of the building. It largely consists of a series of round-headed mirrors around which—and sometimes over which—a profusion of silver-gilt stucco tumbles, featuring animals, cornucopias, cherubs, plants, and musical instruments. Where it strays onto the cool blue of the domed ceiling, it metamorphoses into a series of exotic landscapes.

Gothic features are the three richly carved ogee (S-shaped) arches on the main facade and the massive flying buttresses that line the nave. Over it all, on its tall drum with double three-quarter columns and high, round-headed windows, rises the authentically Baroque dome.

Frauenkirche

Location Dresden, Germany

However surprising it may be that Dresden's Lutheran Frauenkirche, completed in 1743, was built in a style so closely associated with Catholicism, it is an emphatically bold Baroque building on a towering scale. Other than the projecting semicircular chancel at the east end, it is centrally planned. The three remaining facades, all with large, round-headed windows, have broken pediments on giant pilasters. The corners are angled and topped by curved cornices from which rise ornate towers. Above them is a steep-sided dome crowned by a lantern under an onion dome. The echoing interior is brightly lit. The building was largely destroyed in World War II and rebuilt, using some of the original stones, between 1992 and 2005.

Rottenbuch Abbey

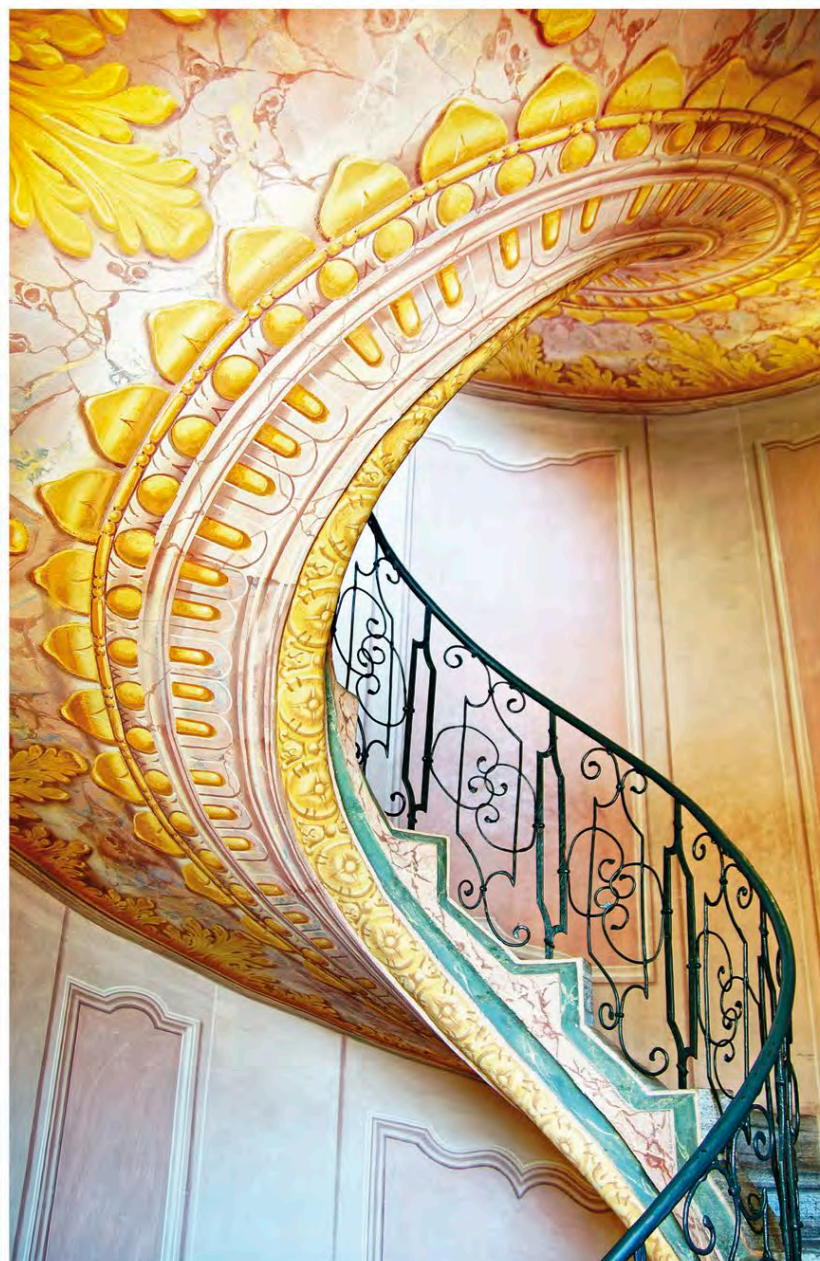
Location Rottenbuch, Germany

Rottenbuch Abbey in the foothills of the Bavarian Alps almost perfectly encapsulates the Bavarian affinity with the Rococo. Built between 1085 and 1125, the church itself is Romanesque and traditionally laid out with a nave, aisles, a crossing, and a chancel. In the mid-18th century, the interior was transformed by stuccoist Josef Schmuzer and fresco painter Matthäus Günther. The building's original Gothic architecture was smothered in stucco—mainly pink, white, and gold. Inside, Günther's illusionistic frescoes dramatically extend the real space of the building into imaginary heavens above.

New Cathedral

Location Salamanca, Spain

Salamanca's New Cathedral is a true hybrid. A late-Gothic cathedral of exceptional splendor, begun in 1513, it boasts an 18th-century Baroque dome over its crossing and a similarly domed bell tower. Adding to the incongruity is the fact that the city's original 12th-century Old Cathedral is not only still intact but effectively forms part of the southern wall of the New Cathedral. The most impressive elements of the building's 16th- and 17th-century



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